THE SHE LIST



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

GUIDING FORCE

Chandrika Kaushik, *55*
D-G (Production Coordination & Services Interaction), DRDO

ACCOMPLISHMENT
Has advanced the cause of Aatmanirbhar Bharat in multiple defence projects

OFTEN, SHE'S THE ONLY WOMAN IN THE ROOM when Chandrika Kaushik is meeting defence experts to assess the needs of the armed forces. Her opinion, though, has mattered. The Indian military has gained in strength from the Aatmanirbhar projects she has shepherded. The IAF has acquired lithe muscle with LCA Tejas, the Indian Navy is torpedoing with Varunastra, while the army is now in possession of the advanced towed artillery gun system. The India-made artillery gun, in fact, boomed loud and clear on Independence Day last year.

Being the child of schoolteacher parents gave Chandrika a strong academic base. She did computer science at Miranda House, Delhi, and MBA from FMS, Delhi. How did she gravitate toward defence? "My uncle was in the IAF, and was a role model. I was drawn to defence science because of the unique blend of innovation, national security and technological advancement," she says. Chandrika's Ph.D. was on PPP in defence, the current focus of government and industry alike.

In the three decades she has spent at the Defence Research & Development Organisation, Chandrika has been involved in missile programmes, implementing advanced planning and resource management tools and fostering pivotal interaction between DRDO and the tri-services from project inception to final execution and support. Her strategic role requires her to have a keen foresight to anticipate defence needs and orchestrate a comprehensive response.

In her journey so far, Chandrika has faced the same hurdles as other working women—work-life balance, navigating a male-dominated field. Also, having to update her skills with evolving technologies. But, then, the dynamic nature of her field, the need for constant learning and the opportunity to work on projects with a real and tangible impact on national security are what drive her. ■

–Pradip R. Sagar

CONQUER YOUR ENEMY

"Never be afraid of challenge. Challenge brings out the best in you"

WHEN NOT WORKING...

...Chandrika is out trekking. She is also a passionate Bharatanatyam dancer